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Realism and the Ethics of War and Peace

David R. Mapel

BECAUSE “REALISM” is a term with many meanings, it is best to begin this chapter by noting what will *not* be discussed here. Realism as it is understood in the current academic international relations literature of “neo-realism” will not be discussed. This sort of realism is intended as a descriptive or empirical account of international relations, whereas the essays in this volume are primarily concerned with prescriptive views of international affairs. Nor will this chapter consider realism as the argument that morality should *never* govern state conduct. Some realist authors do make this argument, although it has seldom been put forward without some sort of qualification or equivocation. In fact, the self-appointed critics of realism are usually the ones who portray it as a completely unqualified rejection of morality in international affairs. Finally, this chapter will not try to summarize a disparate body of historical views that may fall under the heading of realism. That job has been ably performed many times before with respect to both classical realists like Thucydides, Machiavelli, and Hobbes, and modern realists like Morgenthau, Niebuhr, and Kennan.

Instead, realism appears here as a philosophical construct designed to respond to the concerns of pacifists, just war theorists, and other moralists of international affairs. Of course, this construct must bear at least a family resemblance to various historical views if it is to deserve the name of realism. Throughout this chapter, I note where similar views have been expressed by classical and modern realists (especially Robert W. Tucker, who perhaps comes closest to being a “realist” in my sense of the term). But my aim is not primarily historical in character. It is, rather, to elicit the logic of realism as a broadly ethical view of war and peace.

Understood in this way, the central claim of prescriptive realism is that morality should not *always* govern state conduct. Though historically realism has often been formulated in a more radical manner—for example, as the view that morality cannot govern state conduct or should never govern state conduct—it is this more moderate formulation of realism that poses the most serious challenge to other traditions of thought about the ethics of war and peace. Without pulling the teeth of realism, it forms the basis of a powerful challenge to more conventional ways of understanding the role of morality in international relations.

This challenge can be developed in three different ways. First, with respect to *ius ad bellum*, realism argues that strict observance of legal and moral prohibitions against aggression must sometimes compromise the state's security or survival. Second, with respect to *ius in bello*, realism argues that even wars fought for limited ends and with limited means must sometimes involve the deliberate killing of innocent people. Finally, some writers have insisted that both the ends and the means of war normally can and should be limited, but have argued that states are not bound to observe such limits in extreme situations. Although this last alternative is usually not thought of as fully realist in character, the idea of extremity as a justification or excuse has been of central importance in the realist tradition. For this reason, I will consider this last argument as a third way of expressing the central challenge of realism.

Unless the critic of realism can establish that morality is always of overriding importance, then any of these arguments, if true, is sufficient to establish the central claim of realism. For each argument identifies a different situation in which morality would appear to require a sacrifice of territorial integrity or political independence by the state. This is not to say that the state should never surrender some of its territory or independence for the sake of morality. Nor is it to deny that historically the requirements of morality have been understood in a variety of ways. It is to assert that unless the fundamental interests of the state are considered "just" by definition, the state will sometimes face situations in which those interests will conflict with morality.¹ Realists argue that in such situations, morality should not always prevail in the conduct of statecraft.

WAR AND PEACE

Historically, realists have often argued that international relations is a Hobbesian "state of nature" that is also a "state of war." If the three arguments above constitute the core of the realist approach to the ethics of war and peace, however, then prescriptive realism is not inherently committed to the view that international relations is a zero-sum game or war of all against all. The prescriptive claims of realism may remain plausible even in an international environment very different from the one we inhabit now. Let us make the "unrealistic" assumption that the normal condition of international relations is one of peaceful cooperation. Even in such a peaceable kingdom, it could remain the case, both in principle and upon rare occasion, that the state might require (and should use) force to defend itself, and that even a limited use of force would harm innocent people in unjust ways. Understood as a distinctive view of the role of morality in international relations, realism is logically compatible with a wide range of empirical assumptions about the character of international society. Many

criticisms of realism as a descriptive view of international relations are therefore simply beside the point in the present context.

Nevertheless, it is true that the hard questions identified by prescriptive realism do not arise unless we assume that there are occasions when the state must use force to secure its own vital interests or survival. And historically, realists have often argued that international relations does resemble a Hobbesian state of war, understood not as a condition of actual force but as “a tract of time, wherein the will to contend by battle is sufficiently known.”² But others have rejected this definition of war as broad enough to rationalize almost any kind of preemptive violence as defensive in character. Theorists in other ethical traditions have often focused on questions of definition because they wish to show that war is an inherently social activity and therefore both norm-governed and voluntary rather than necessary. Above all, these critics of realism wish to contest the sort of definition of war offered by Clausewitz: “War is an act of force . . . which must lead, in theory, to extremes.”³

Clausewitz argued that the social conditions “which circumscribe and moderate [war] . . . are not part of war: they already exist.”⁴ Yet Clausewitz also argued that “if we keep in mind that war springs from some political purpose, it is natural that the prime cause of existence will remain the supreme consideration in conducting it.”⁵ In other words, Clausewitz appreciated that real, as opposed to theoretical or definitional, war involves choice. Realists have usually recognized both the social and the voluntary character of war. Yet they agree with Clausewitz that there is a dialectic of violence in war that tends to replace the aims of policy with the aims of total military victory. Realists thus acknowledge with Clausewitz that war “may be a matter of degree,” but they are inclined to fear war precisely because it has a tendency to outrun initial policies and limitations.⁶ The critical question for the realist is not therefore whether total war falls within the definition of war, but whether this kind of war represents the abandonment of policy. In many cases (most notably, nuclear war), some realists have argued that it does.

If we still want a definition of war, then perhaps we can say that for realists, war is “organized violence carried out by political units against each other,” with organized interstate violence understood as one species of war.⁷ According to this definition, what distinguishes war from other forms of violence is its official character, although questions remain about what makes it official and what degree or kind of violence is required to distinguish war from peace. The vagueness of this definition is unlikely to bother realists, however: they are comfortable with any definition broad enough to include undeclared wars, total wars, and some kinds of internal conflict and rebellion.

For similar reasons, realists have not been interested in defining peace. Realists are generally resistant to any equation of peace with justice, since

this would suggest that there can be no peace in the absence of agreement about justice. They are more likely to define peace simply as the absence of organized violence. They insist that peace and justice sometimes can and do conflict, although they may grant that justice is sometimes a condition of lasting peace.⁸ But only sometimes: claims of justice appear in many cases to be a condition of protracted violence, as current struggles over national self-determination illustrate.

WAR AND NONVIOLENCE

Though realists have occasionally celebrated war, they have usually deplored it on the prudential grounds that war always poses a risk to the state. Because they are skeptical about attempts to reconcile prudence and morality, they have often had a keen sense of the immorality of war as well. Not only are the causes and conduct of war often unjust, but character and even language deteriorate during war, as Thucydides noted in his frightening description of the civil war in Corcyra.⁹ The same sorts of prudence and skepticism explain realist attitudes toward nonviolence, and particularly pacifism.¹⁰ Both realists and pacifists are skeptical about many of the distinctions of just war theory. On this basis, some realists agree with pacifists that a consistent commitment to fundamental principles of common morality requires the rejection of war. But these realists think that the pacifist rejection of war is deeply imprudent: "For a man who wants to make a profession of good in all regards must come to ruin among so many who are not good."¹¹ Other realists think that the pacifist rejection of war is not only imprudent but immoral as well, since these realists think that the distinction that common morality draws between doing and allowing harm cannot be sustained. Pacifism should be morally condemned because in refusing to use force to prevent the ruin of some, it allows the ruin of all.

In response, it may be insisted that there is an important difference between doing and allowing. Much more broadly, it may be argued that it is realism, not pacifism, that is not only clearly immoral but imprudent as well. Nuclear weapons have finally revealed to everyone that the most serious threat to human values is the use of force in behalf of the state. Prudence dictates that we give up the state.¹²

Realists are inclined to doubt that the existence of nuclear weapons shows that the state can no longer secure the ends that human beings have traditionally desired, such as security, just change, and political independence. Instead, they are likely to argue that if we give up the state, we must also be prepared to give up those ends, like political freedom, that the state has traditionally defended. No prudent person can expect nonviolence to secure the traditional ends of the state against adversaries willing to use extreme measures. In other words, realists doubt arguments for nonviolence and against the state that appeal to our prudential self-interest.

They are equally dubious about appeals to our higher nature or to the possibility of moral transformation, and these doubts have usually reflected various theological or psychological assumptions about the sinfulness or natural egoism of human beings. But there seems to be no reason why realists must claim that such change is impossible. Instead, realism might simply argue that such change seems unlikely enough: with some rare exceptions, nonviolence is not a strategy for preserving political independence, and at present human beings appear to desire political independence as much as ever.

If human beings cannot be weaned from wanting what only the state can presently secure, then perhaps the state system can be replaced by a world authority with enough power to require world disarmament, to enforce world peace, to compel just change, and to preserve at least a large degree of political autonomy. Here realists are likely to worry about the tremendous dangers that must attend the tremendous power that such a world authority would require. Aside from standard worries about world tyranny, there is also a worry about chaos. Kenneth Waltz, for example, argues that if a central authority is strong enough to control secession, strong states will be tempted to struggle to control the reins of world government; if the center is weak, efforts to break free may be prevalent, leading to a world of civil war.¹³ Of course, if the main sources of international conflict were to wither away, an effective world authority might not require such great power.¹⁴ Realists who begin from pessimistic assumptions about human nature deny this possibility. But although such assumptions have historically been of great importance in the realist tradition, they do not seem to be a necessary part of realism. Again, realism understood as a prescriptive ethic of international relations is logically compatible with a wide variety of assumptions about the possibility and desirability of international transformation. It may be both a theoretical and a moral failing of realism that it has traditionally not paid much attention to questions about how states should act to transform international relations. On the other hand, questions about how states may act in nonideal circumstances would appear to be equally important. Indeed, we must be able to answer these questions before we can know what states may do in the process of moving toward a more peaceful world.

THE GROUNDS FOR WAR

Realists think that war can in principle serve peace or justice by enforcing international law, by preserving a balance of power, or by promoting change. For this reason, realists do not subscribe to the view that war is no longer an effective means of achieving these ends. Yet although war may sometimes promote peace or just change, realists are much more concerned with war as a means of preserving the state, and are likely to feel

some affinity for the view that the only justifiable wars are those fought in defense of the state or the political community. From a realist perspective, there are two objections to restricting the justification of war to self-defense. First, there is no very clear way of limiting the definition of aggression, and therefore the idea of self-defense, without sometimes undercutting the claim of states to preserve their territorial integrity and political sovereignty. Second, it may at times prove necessary to wage wars that clearly go beyond self-defense, however defined, in order to protect national security.

Realists are likely to agree that the most satisfactory definition of aggression includes the idea of imminent threat. This definition of aggression recognizes that the initiation of force can be defensive in character when it is a response to an immediate, grave, and manifest threat to state survival. Although some critics of the just war have objected that this definition of aggression permits states to initiate force whenever they believe that they face an imminent threat, this is not a criticism that realists are likely to make.¹⁵ For although there are borderline cases, these criteria are clear enough to allow us at least sometimes to judge that beliefs about the existence of an imminent threat are unreasonable or insincere. From a realist perspective, the difficulty with this kind of definition is rather that the state's independence can also be compromised by measures that are nonforceful and less than imminent, such as economic destabilization or perhaps a prolonged state of mobilization that drains resources. In some situations, it may be indispensable for the state to act "aggressively" and therefore "unjustly" in order to avoid a nonforceful danger that will prove no less fatal than military conquest.

It has sometimes been argued that this notion of preemptive war as an indispensable means to state survival exaggerates the degree of strategic knowledge and foresight possessed by political actors.¹⁶ The preemptive (actually, preventive) wars recommended by Machiavelli, for example, clearly rest on exaggerated claims to know how states will and must act. But though historically, realists often have made exaggerated predictive claims, only the most optimistic advocate of nonviolent national defense would assert that force has never been an indispensable means of defending the state against an immediate military threat. Realism insists that at least occasionally, preemptive war can also be an indispensable means of defending the state against grave but nonforceful threats.

In response to these difficulties, we might try to broaden the definition of aggression to include a wider range of threats. In doing so, we might find that we can sometimes agree about particular cases. Yet realists think there is little hope of general and lasting agreement on the interpretation and application of legal definitions of aggression, since in interpreting such definitions, states always have conflicting interests in stressing the importance of both world stability and national sovereignty.¹⁷ Although the

chances of agreement within the UN Security Council about the interpretation of aggression may have improved recently, realists doubt whether this development expresses anything except a temporary phase of American hegemony following the end of the Cold War. If the state does consistently try to conform to a definition of aggression that can be clearly interpreted and applied, the consequences may prove dire. In short, realism argues that it is impossible for the state to conform to clear rules of *ius ad bellum* without sometimes compromising its own security.

Historically, realists have also argued that sometimes not only preemptive but also preventive wars are necessary. In the case of preventive war, such claims of necessity may indeed attribute a kind of strategic clairvoyance to governments. Such claims of necessity may also reflect exaggerated fears about long-term political trends that will eventually leave a state isolated in a hostile world. Writers in the tradition generally agree with Hobbes, however, that it is natural for human beings to reason about dangers before they become immediate, and that such reasoning is often far from paranoid. As Michael Howard asks, was it paranoid for the British to worry about the revival of German power in the 1930s? Was it unreasonable in 1939 that “nearly all the British felt justified in going to war, not over any specific issue that could have been settled by negotiation, but *to maintain their power* while it was still possible”?¹⁸ Since Germany had already violated international law in 1939, the Second World War was not, strictly speaking, a preventive war. But as Michael Howard suggests, the principal reason for the British decision to declare war was fear of German hegemony. Of course, the retrospective conclusion drawn by many that there should have been a preventive war in the 1930s has strongly influenced postwar conceptions of the legitimate use of force (the so-called Munich analogy), as illustrated by President Bush’s rationale for his war against Iraq. Nevertheless, it may be argued that all wars that are motivated by fear of hegemony alone are unjust: there must be a more definite threat before war can be justified. Realists, however, are reluctant to condemn all such wars on the grounds that aggression itself is wrong, or that aggression anywhere is a threat to peace everywhere, or that aggression is a crime against international society. They are even more reluctant to move beyond the condemnation of aggression to the waging of war *against* aggression. For this tradition, enforcing international law cannot by itself constitute a sufficient reason for going to war.

Because realism refuses to justify war on legal, moral, or religious grounds, it is a doctrine that in some respects limits violence. Indeed, realists have argued that it is really moralism in foreign policy that most frequently leads to violence, not realism. But moralism is not morality: morality is not a set of simple rules but a complex structure that includes many distinctions and exceptions.¹⁹ Yet some realists have argued that morality should occupy a subordinate role in foreign policy precisely because the

complex character of moral reasoning tends to get lost in practice. In practice, the following fallacious line of reasoning is all too tempting: Because aggression is an evil, it is something states are morally responsible for choosing. If there is moral responsibility, then aggression is not merely an evil, but an unnecessary evil. Aggression must stem from the miscalculations of aggressors, not from powerful underlying social and political grievances. Such miscalculations must therefore be deterred and punished. The realist claims that historically, this way of viewing aggression has tempted statesmen to oversimplify: from this perspective, peace tends to become indivisible, war tends to become a stark conflict over justice, and the distinction between *ius ad bellum* and *ius in bello* tends to become blurred. Traditional statecraft, which has historically focused on discriminations of "power, interest and circumstance," is gradually replaced by the idea of collective security, which tends to disregard these considerations in favor of the rights of all states, great and small, against aggression wherever and however it may occur.²⁰ No doubt this crude reasoning is not inherent in a moral approach to foreign policy: moralists can indeed make sound prudential judgments, and the doctrine of collective security can be given a more sophisticated formulation. It may also be doubted whether historically there is such a stark opposition between traditional statecraft and the sort of Wilsonian idealism that is the usual target of realist criticisms. Yet realists have often argued that even if the idea of national security is itself quite vague, their approach to foreign policy is in practice less subject to abuse than its alternatives.²¹

Realism is in one sense more permissive about the grounds for war than many other traditions, since it sometimes sanctions wars of self-preservation as well as wars of self-defense. But realists claim that their principles are in another sense far less permissive than those of other views, since they do not sanction wars between the forces of good and evil. In criticism of realism, it may be said that realism is more willing to permit aggression and less willing to oppose it than other traditions. In reply, it may be said that realism is more tolerant of peaceful negotiation with the devil than other traditions, on the grounds that negotiation is usually less risky and less destructive than confrontation on the basis of principle.²² As we shall see in the next section, realists generally refuse to demonize the unsavory foreign states with which governments must sometimes deal.

RESISTANCE TO POLITICAL AUTHORITY

In considering realist views of resistance to political authority, it will be helpful to distinguish between two versions of reason of state. "Patriotic" reason of state regards the state as being of fundamental value. Pericles' speeches, for example, express the view that Athens has "attained an independent existence such that her preservation means more than the happi-

ness or misery of all her inhabitants.”²³ In contrast, “liberal” reason of state regards the state as merely an instrument or condition for realizing more fundamental values, albeit an indispensable condition. Lincoln’s speeches, for example, express this view of the Union as indispensable to the preservation of universal moral and political principles. In practice, this distinction between patriotic and liberal reasons of state sometimes may not make much difference, for in the actual conduct of foreign policy, an indispensable condition of fundamental value might just as well be regarded as itself a fundamental value. In theory, the distinction is important because it suggests that realism is compatible with a wide range of views about the basis of state authority and resistance to authority.²⁴

The importance of the distinction between patriotic and liberal reasons of state can be illustrated by considering a standard criticism of realism. It is sometimes argued that because realism is committed to doing whatever is necessary to preserve the state, nothing in the logic of realism forbids the hunting down of internal enemies of the state. This logic is most clearly illustrated in Machiavelli, who recommends political murder as a tool of statecraft. In response, it should be said that a great deal depends on the kind of view in question. Liberal realists regard the state as being instrumental to other ends, and in many cases the principal end is political liberty. For this reason, liberal realists have sometimes insisted that conscription can only be justified given a compelling threat to the state; that free speech, conscientious objection, civil disobedience, and every other form of peaceful protest must be tolerated by the state up to the point of imminent constitutional crisis, rebellion, and civil war; that free elections, free speech, and many forms of protest must be permitted during the course of civil (and foreign) wars; and that during such crises political leaders may sometimes suspend certain rights but should resist taking on any new, unconstitutional powers.

Nevertheless, should all constitutional measures to preserve the state fail, even liberal realists are likely to argue that a state may temporarily use unconstitutional measures against its own citizens, as long as those measures ultimately serve to reestablish the liberal state.²⁵ This is simply the internal side of realism’s more general approach to politics itself: if the state may sometimes make war against foreigners when its survival is threatened, and if war involves forcing innocent people to kill each other, then the state may sometimes take extreme measures toward its own citizens for the same reasons. There is some truth, then, in the criticism that realism finds itself on a slippery slope with respect to the way in which the state may treat its citizens. The realist rejoinder is that states do sometimes find themselves on such a slope, whether they like it or not. Liberal realists add that the slope is not as slippery as their critics suggest. There may be safe stops on the way down.

Realists take much the same position with regard to foreign repression. In principle, liberal realists will discriminate between foreign states that permit peaceful resistance to authority and those that do not. On liberal principles, only the former are entitled to resist revolution. Though liberal realists may condemn foreign repression, they do not regard such repression as remarkable, nor do they think that we should always respond to foreign repression by breaking off diplomatic recognition (much less by launching reform interventions). Realists recognize that a repressive or illiberal form of government can sometimes express the history, culture, and values of a community. In other words, the state can serve as an indispensable condition for a variety of political values. More importantly, realists usually view the state as an indispensable condition of order. Although revolution is sometimes the expression of a just desire for self-determination, realists think it has more often been an occasion for bloodletting on an enormous scale that has spilled across borders and become international. In short, with respect to internal resistance both inside and outside the state, the security perspective predominates. This perspective sometimes leads realists to recommend military intervention in behalf of repressive governments. Historically, realists have often failed to see that such interventions are seldom necessary to the state's interests, let alone its survival. But no tradition has a monopoly on political stupidity.²⁶

Of course, many realists have not been liberals at all, even in the broad sense of the term I have been using. And realists who have been liberals have often grossly exaggerated the need for internal control within the liberal state. In my judgment, this willingness to accept the state on almost any terms is one of the weakest aspects of the realist perspective. By contrast, realism is at its strongest when it argues that internal necessities of state can sometimes exist for even relatively just states. Strong constitutional safeguards for internal dissent may not always permit the liberal state to defend itself against external and internal enemies in a just manner, especially when those enemies combine. In extreme cases, even liberal realists will argue that the state must sometimes suspend the rule of law.

INTENTION AND MOTIVE

Although it is difficult to say exactly how we should distinguish intention and motive, we do have an intuitive grasp of the distinction. Very roughly, intention is what a person aims at, as when a soldier shoots with the intention of killing an enemy in war; motive, on the other hand, is "perhaps expressive of the spirit" in which a person shoots, rather than descriptive of the end to which the shooting was a means.²⁷ Given this way of drawing the distinction, it appears possible to form the same intentions and perform

the same actions from a variety of different motives. We may act with the intention of killing, for example, out of pity or hatred.

Instead of stressing philosophical difficulties in distinguishing between intention and motive, however, realists have historically tended to emphasize various practical problems. It is difficult to be certain of the intentions of others, and in particular, states do not always enjoy the luxury of trying to distinguish between the aggressive and defensive intentions of other states.²⁸ The attempt to set clear legal and moral limits on the defensive intentions of states must sometimes fail. The good intentions of moralists in foreign policy often lead to more suffering than happiness. And, as we shall see, some realists also think that just war theorists use the distinction between intending and foreseeing harm to disguise the hellishness of war.

Because realists think that political leaders and soldiers sometimes must intend what is wrong, the idea of motive tends to become more important in the realist tradition. Indeed, we might almost describe realism as an ethic of motivation. To a large extent, realism shifts our attention from the evils that we sometimes intentionally bring about to the spirit in which we bring them about. Some interpreters argue, for example, that St. Augustine was a “Christian realist” because he shifted the focus of our moral judgments about war from intentions to motives, and then argued that because we can neither be certain of motives nor act without sin, we must fall back on what is certain, namely, the laws of the state. On this interpretation, the real evil of war for Augustine is not that soldiers sometimes intentionally kill innocent people, but that soldiers sometimes intentionally kill innocent people out of motives of hatred and cruelty rather than reluctantly and in obedience to law.²⁹ Machiavelli stressed that a prince should not want to use cruelty for its own sake, and that motive is therefore one of the things that determines whether a prince has *virtù*.³⁰ More recently, Joel Rosenthal has argued that many American realists were influenced by Max Weber’s notion of an “ethic of responsibility,” which subordinates intentions to consequences and motives.³¹ For Weber, the idea of motive seems to serve as a bridge between the ethical and political concerns of the statesman; in Weber’s phrase, it determines “who can” have a true vocation for politics. According to Weber, the statesman who has such a vocation will do the responsible thing by getting his hands dirty, as he sometimes must, in the pursuit of higher ideals.³² Reinhold Niebuhr also stressed that the statesman must act out of a sense of responsibility, although the exercise of responsible power brings moral guilt with it. In a famous passage on American foreign policy, Niebuhr noted that “the irony of our situation lies in the fact that we could not be virtuous (in the sense of practicing the virtues implicit in meeting our vast world responsibilities) if we were as innocent as we pretend to be.”³³ Realists have

often suggested that the goodness of motive redeems or at least limits the evil of intent.

The above quotation from Niebuhr raises two problems, however. First, it is hard to see from a realist perspective how the state can have any major “world responsibilities,” at least in the sense of moral responsibility. For realists, the primary aim of foreign policy must be to preserve the state, or as Elihu Root said, to keep the state out of trouble. Whenever possible, a policy of isolation would seem to be more in keeping with realism than a policy of engagement (although historically, realists have often argued that a failure to impose world order will lead to world chaos, thus endangering domestic security). Second, how do we judge that the motives of American statesmen have been the “responsible” (that is, right or desirable) ones? In some cases, the answer to this question may be clear, but certainly not in all. If we are told that American statesmen have acted with desirable motives because they are responsible men of virtue, the answer will be circular if being virtuous depends on acting with the correct motives. If we are told that we can judge their motives by their actions, we seem to have left an ethic of motivation behind. Alternatively, the way we describe the actions of statesmen may contain an implicit and question-begging reference to motive—“this is mercy-killing, not murder,” for example. Nevertheless, an ethic of motivation may often be the best we can do in international relations, or so some realists have argued.

Realists frequently see a sharp contrast between the motives of real politicians and the motives of the ideal leader with a “vocation” for politics. Real politicians are primarily motivated by a desire to acquire (“truly a very natural and ordinary thing,” in Machiavelli’s view).³⁴ In contrast, the ideal statesman wants to do the right thing and is morally anguished by some of the choices he faces. The first description of motives is cynical, the second has become banal. But the second description is so familiar precisely because political leaders so often embrace a realist ethic of motivation. Candidates for office often tell us that we want someone who can make “the tough choices,” particularly in foreign policy. We might be pardoned for thinking that they sometimes mean by this to suggest that we want someone who can make immoral choices as well.

THE CONDUCT OF WAR

Historically, both just war theorists and realists have tended to focus on the causes and ends justifying war. Yet if the conduct of war is inherently unlimited, then many would argue that the issue of just cause becomes academic. Realism generally rejects the view that there are any inherent limits on the means that states may threaten or use to preserve themselves. In contrast, other ethical traditions, and particularly the natural law just

war tradition, argue that there are such limits. The most important of these is a principle of discrimination that forbids intentionally attacking the innocent.

If *ius in bello* is to have any distinctive quality, the principle of discrimination cannot rest on some kind of appeal to the bad consequences that will result from failing to observe it. It cannot rest on the view that evil-doing inevitably corrupts the agent, or that the means of action are themselves the ends of action coming into existence.³⁵ Rather, the principle of discrimination must rest on the more basic principle that one may never do evil that good may come of it. For traditional accounts of *ius in bello*, what is evil about certain actions cannot be explained simply in terms of the negative value of certain consequences, but must be found in the intentions that give those actions their character. But according to some realists, this traditional understanding of the basis of *ius in bello* only illustrates its implausibility, because it rules out even the threat to do evil: "In this case, we are left with a position that an act which is unjust to commit ought never to be threatened, however remote the contingency that the act will ever be committed and whatever the consequences that may follow if the threat is abandoned. . . . When reduced to this pure form, the argument seems singularly unpersuasive. One may question whether the moralists themselves are prepared to accept it."³⁶

Many moralists are quite willing to accept this view, however. More importantly, many moralists argue that the implications of this view will often not prove so radical, once we distinguish harm that is intended from harm that is foreseen but unintended. When combined with other moral considerations, such as proportionality, this distinction yields the principle of "double effect."

Although realists have usually rejected double effect, historically they have seldom paid much attention to the theory of action that the doctrine presupposes or to the other philosophical issues it raises. The most problematical aspect of the doctrine of double effect is the requirement that we should not intentionally harm the innocent as a means to our end. This requirement raises problems of interpretation, problems of consistency between the prescriptions it has been used to justify, and problems concerning the moral relevance of the distinction between side effects and what is intended. Attempts to deal with these problems have given rise to many different versions of the doctrine. Unfortunately, it is impossible to discuss all of the ways in which double effect has been criticized and defended.³⁷ Given the powerful and conflicting intuitions that people have about it, as well as the philosophical attention that it continues to command, it would be foolish to make any flat assertions about whether the doctrine can ultimately be defended. Instead, we should focus on how a realist rejection of the double effect alters our view of *ius in bello*.

Even if we think there is little moral difference between some of the harms we intend in waging war and some of the harms we merely foresee as a side effect of war, discrimination may continue to function as a subordinate principle of just warfare. If we can achieve the same military objective by killing soldiers or by killing both soldiers and civilians, for example, then obviously we can be blamed for not choosing the first, more discriminating alternative. If we reject double effect, motive will also remain important to our moral assessment of individual and state actors, since motive and intent differ. But if we reject double effect, it follows that “collateral” harm to the innocent must often be regarded as either deliberate or intentional. Absent some other justifying or excusing conditions, moral responsibility for such harm must be accepted, once we have done whatever we can to avoid such harm within the constraints of military necessity.

Furthermore, once we reject double effect, the wrong that is done in war will not involve merely the deliberate killing of noncombatants who are morally and technically “innocent,” that is, “harmless.” Many combatants appear to be innocent in both senses as well. Many soldiers have been forced to fight, and are therefore at least partly absolved of moral responsibility for the justice of their cause. But many soldiers are also harmless in the sense of not posing any immediate danger to other individuals and therefore not engaging their rights of self-defense. In war, soldiers often do not exercise rights of self-defense. Rather, they exercise rights of self-preservation by attacking soldiers who are green recruits, who are far behind the lines, or who otherwise present no immediate danger. If we may permissibly kill these soldiers, it may only be permissible because of a convention that allows us to treat them “as if” they are always dangerous.³⁸ Finally, on the basis of self-defense, it would also seem that soldiers may sometimes permissibly kill not only enemy soldiers who are not in fact dangerous, but also noncombatants who are not dangerous, who only shield a dangerous threat.³⁹ But if the normal conduct of war usually involves all of these kinds of killing, and if the rejection of double effect means that there is no necessary moral difference between intentional and foreseen harms, then it would appear that there is considerable support for the realist view that war constitutes a kind of activity that cannot be justified by common morality (without an appeal to some other excusing conditions).

In light of these criticisms of discrimination, the other basic principle of *ius in bello*, proportionality, obviously becomes much more important to our assessment of the conduct of war. Realists have argued amongst themselves and with their critics about how we should make judgments of proportionality and about how exact such judgments can be. They have acknowledged, or been forced to acknowledge, that such judgments must be quite crude. Nevertheless, all realists agree that there can be no statecraft

without judgments of proportionality. Indeed, the idea of proportionality is of central importance to political realism. Even though realists are willing to accept the indiscriminate nature of nuclear deterrence, for example, they are generally unwilling to accept the idea that nuclear war could meet criteria of proportionality.

Though realists recognize the moral importance of impartial calculations of proportionality, they stress that states never in fact calculate proportionality in this way. As we shall see below, realists also hold that impartial calculations should not be of overriding importance to the state. They sometimes do make essentially utilitarian arguments, such as that it is in everyone's long-run interest for states to base their foreign policies strictly on self-interest. The argument that British terror bombing in the Second World War was justified because the Nazis posed a general threat to civilization can also be construed in a utilitarian or consequentialist way. But though the empirical assumptions of such arguments might be described as realist in character, there is nothing essentially realist about their moral assumptions. These arguments assume that we should be concerned about the welfare of humanity, not the welfare of a particular state or community. Distinctively realist arguments only begin to emerge when extreme measures are justified in terms of the interests of the members of a particular state.

A distinction is sometimes drawn between vulgar versions of realism that require everyday amorality or immorality from officials, and more sophisticated versions of realism that require only that officials be willing to override morality in rare situations involving communal survival or supreme emergency. This distinction presupposes that states usually have room to observe the traditional principles of *ius in bello*. It also presupposes that the traditional principles of *ius in bello* can be defended against philosophical criticism. If these standards cannot be justified, then even limited wars must violate a fundamental moral prohibition against intentionally harming the innocent (and may prove morally unacceptable in many other ways as well). This conclusion would not show that officials must always behave in amoral or immoral ways, but it would show that it is actually vulgar realism that best expresses the truth about the conduct of war.

MORALITY AND EXTREMITY

At the beginning of this essay, I noted that although historically, realism has sometimes been understood as the view that morality has no place in public life, it is better understood as the view that there are limits to the role of morality in public life. In other words, the central claim of realism is that morality should not *always* govern the conduct of states. States sometimes ought to be governed by considerations of self-preservation,

and therefore ought at least sometimes to subordinate religious, moral, and utilitarian considerations to that end. But what is meant by saying that the state “ought” to preserve itself, if this is neither a religious nor a moral nor a utilitarian “ought”? Assuming we can make sense of this claim, what criticisms of religion, common morality, and consequentialism support it? Finally, if the state ought to ignore or override the demands of religion, morality, and utility sometimes, why not always? Can realists consistently maintain that the state should normally observe the constraints of morality but should violate those constraints in situations involving communal survival or supreme emergency? The realist outlook is compatible with many different answers to these questions, and we can consider only a few of them.

Before discussing these views, however, some cautionary remarks are in order. Obviously, morality comprises much of what makes an individual life go well: moral and prudential values, we might say, interpenetrate each other. Just as obviously, philosophers have disagreed not only about the relationship between prudence and morality, but also about how we should understand each independently. Given these complexities, the following schema is bound to be crude. Nevertheless, it may serve as one way of organizing our thoughts about a wide variety of views.

With this warning in mind, we can say that historically, realists have offered two views of the relationship between prudence and morality. The first *defines* the moral life in terms of the necessary conditions for the good life for individuals, which includes membership in the community. Various patriotic or communitarian realists present strong versions of this view; Hobbes, Niebuhr, and others present weaker versions that focus on the necessity of the state given the fact that people are often not moved to do what common morality seems to require. The second view defines the moral life and the good life independently, and argues that the good life always or sometimes *overrides* the moral life. Thrasymachus in the *Republic* presents a strong version of this view; those who defend a realist “escape clause” for supreme emergencies present a weaker version.

The purest example of patriotic realism is found in the speeches of Pericles in the *Peloponnesian War*. As David Grene puts it, “In the greatness of the thing created, the [Athenian] empire, there is a quality different from the qualities that created it; it is great in itself and for itself.”⁴⁰ Robert Osgood faintly echoes this view when he writes that “so intimate is man’s identification with his national group that national extinction, like the murder of own’s family . . . would destroy a virtually indispensable source of personal security and happiness, as well as the sum of all those personal satisfactions derived from the nation’s way of life.”⁴¹ These views treat the state as being of fundamental value, and lead to what I have called patriotic reason of state. Clearly, for patriotic reason of state there can be

no radical conflict between prudence and morality, since the state is the most important value. Extreme measures in situations of supreme emergency present no special problem. Today, however, virtually no one is willing to regard the state as having transcendent value, and many are skeptical that the state is even the source of the most important values. Though human beings may be social by nature, many theorists reject the view that they are political by nature. Most theorists also reject any easy equation of the state with the community. Even if this equation were accepted, the values embodied in any particular community are often purportedly universal in character. They may also be deeply objectionable. For these and a variety of other reasons, it is difficult to equate the state with the community or to understand either as being of fundamental value. Nevertheless, patriotic reason of state has historically been an important part of the realist tradition.

More persuasive is the Hobbesian view that we should not devise abstract systems of morality that most people cannot consistently follow and that therefore have little or no relationship to social reality.⁴² For Hobbes, it is a condition of any morality that individuals (and therefore collectives) be generally capable of complying with its demands.⁴³ In extreme situations, individuals are generally incapable of complying with moral demands for self-sacrifice. Such demands are generally ineffective and therefore unreasonable as moral requirements. Strictly speaking, this view does not hold that individuals and states should ignore or override the demands of morality in extreme situations, but rather redefines the demands of morality so that individuals and collectives have a *right* to take extreme measures for the sake of self-preservation. The importance of the state, on this view, is that it removes the necessity for individuals to exercise their right of self-preservation. The state becomes an indispensable condition of the most minimal and urgent prudential value, namely, physical survival. Of course, the notorious difficulty with this view is that it would seem to undercut demands to defend the state as often as it would justify extreme actions in defense of the state. According to Hobbes, as long as we have a state to protect us, any state will do, including a foreign one. But realists are generally committed not only to the view that the state has a right of self-preservation, but also to the view that the state ought to be defended, sometimes at a very high cost in individual life. Realists have sometimes argued in favor of appeasement, however. Thucydides' Melian dialogue, for example, suggests that the leaders of Melos acted foolishly and thus dishonorably in sacrificing their population to the Athenian sword.⁴⁴

According to Reinhold Niebuhr, it is not individuals but collectives that are generally incapable of self-sacrifice. Unfortunately, although individuals are sometimes capable of self-sacrifice, their altruism is tainted by original sin and almost always expresses itself in a kind of patriotism that is

nothing better than national egoism. Group relations “can never be as ethical as those which characterize individual relations,” and therefore, Niebuhr argues, we need one morality for individuals and another for groups.⁴⁵ Niebuhr’s argument explains how it might be possible to have a morality that effectively demands individual sacrifices for the state but that treats certain kinds of sacrifice by the state as unreasonably demanding. Yet from the higher perspective of Christian morality, both individuals and collectives are “covered in guilt.” Political leaders cannot help doing wrong, particularly because they must exercise “responsible” power. For Niebuhr, whether power is exercised responsibly in turn depends largely on the motive for its exercise, since leaders sometimes cannot avoid intending and doing wrong. Aside from the theological or perhaps psychological assumptions that Niebuhr’s argument requires, then, a great deal depends on the role of motive in public morality.

Realists have also argued that the good life always or sometimes *overrides* morality. A strong version of this view is expressed by some of the characters in Thucydides, for example, and in some of the Platonic dialogues. At times it is argued that a choice to preserve the state is “inevitable” because it is determined by a law of nature. This argument simply denies the possibility of choice and the significance of ethical discourse. A similar view sometimes appears in normative guise, however, in the argument that the strong ought to rule by a law of natural justice. Instead of Niebuhr’s distinction between individual and collective morality, we are now presented with a distinction between the natural morality of the strong and the conventional morality of the weak. Thrasymachus, for example, does not object to conventional morality on the grounds that it sometimes conflicts with our well-being. Rather, common morality is always bad for our well-being. A few followers of Nietzsche notwithstanding, the difficulty with this view is simply that common morality seems to be a very large part of the good life, even if the two are not taken to be identical. Any radical opposition of the two seems unpersuasive.

Realists have often argued that political leaders are trustees who have a special prerogative, indeed a special duty, to take whatever measures are necessary to protect the community.⁴⁶ Since trustees can have no more right to act on behalf of their community than the community has to act for itself, this is not the best way of framing the issue. It is more helpful to ask whether the members of a community sometimes have a special prerogative to act in a way other than morality demands. The scope of such “agent-centered prerogatives” is currently of much interest in contemporary moral theory.⁴⁷ The justification and scope of such prerogatives is unclear, however. For example, it might be thought that individuals should only be exempt from various “imperfect” or “positive” duties of beneficence that seem too demanding, not from various “perfect” or “negative” duties

against harming others. Yet philosophers who have argued for such a prerogative have also attacked these traditional distinctions, opening up the possibility that individuals might have a prerogative of doing some very nasty things to protect their fundamental personal commitments. This view is hard to accept. Yet if the claim that the state may act unjustly in extreme situations can be defended at all, this line of thought may prove suggestive.

The second point about the good life sometimes overriding the moral life is that so far we have discussed this view as a doctrine of justification, not as a doctrine of excuse. In other words, we have been considering the claim that the preservation of the state should sometimes override the demands of morality, not the claim that the state should always observe the demands of morality but may sometimes be excused for not doing so. This latter claim must also be briefly considered, however.

As Michael Walzer has observed, realists often use the term “necessity” in two different ways: certain policies are said to be necessary in the sense of being indispensable means to an end; and certain ends are said to be necessary in the sense of being inevitable or beyond choice.⁴⁸ As Walzer also observes, arguments about the indispensability of means often push us back to arguments about the inevitability of ends. But a strong claim of inevitability does not excuse; rather, it denies that moral terms like excuse have any application to our conduct. The question, then, is whether realists sometimes employ the idea of necessity in a third sense that does identify a set of excusing conditions.

According to some theorists, extreme actions are sometimes excused by “moral necessity.” Unfortunately, so-called moral necessity is neither moral, since it involves immoral actions, nor necessary, since it involves choice. Nevertheless, we can see the point of using this oxymoron: though it may sometimes be clearly wrong for individuals to take innocent life in self-defense, for example, we might try to excuse such actions by pointing to the immense value of physical survival for most people. As Mill described the individual’s claim to physical security: “*Ought* and *should* grow into *must*, and recognized indispensability becomes a moral necessity, analogous to physical, and often not inferior to it in binding force.”⁴⁹ In some situations, there is a combination of elements that might excuse immoral conduct, namely, great psychological pressure, a partial transfer of responsibility to the attacker who has put the victim in a coercive situation, and the immense value that the victim assigns to his own survival. A similar combination of elements might also explain why the state should at least sometimes be excused for violating principles of morality when collective survival is threatened. Of course, just war theorists and pacifists are unwilling to assign such value to the survival of the individual, let alone of the state. Yet although individuals should not assign this sort of value to their

own survival or to the survival of the state, we may be reluctant to blame them, or blame them fully. In choosing to act unjustly, we might say, they only do what anyone but a saint would do. This idea of necessity as a set of excusing conditions does seem to be expressed in many realist writings, although realists have seldom drawn a clear distinction between excuse and justification, much less explored the bearing of this distinction in any careful manner. This is unfortunate, since the idea of excuse might help us reconcile our judgments that certain actions are clearly wrong with our sense that such actions are sometimes necessary. Given a general lack of attention to these issues, it remains an open question whether the idea of necessity as a kind of excuse can be developed in a fruitful way.

CONCLUSION

According to realism, even internally just states sometimes face genuine moral and practical dilemmas in international relations. Yet realists have historically tended to focus on “the” state or all states, rather than on just states alone. This insistently state-centric emphasis is perhaps the most problematical feature of realism. Yet if just states must sometimes act unjustly in order to preserve themselves, we can see the point of this traditional emphasis on “the” state. The difference between just and unjust states diminishes once we accept the view that even just states must sometimes take the apparently self-contradictory course of acting unjustly abroad for the sake of preserving justice at home. Realism views states primarily from the external perspective of their relations with one another. From this perspective, states should perhaps be blamed for not working harder to achieve a more peaceful world, yet states are currently caught within the state system and should not be unduly blamed for responding to its necessities. Or so the realist argues.

This view tends to make most of us distinctly uncomfortable. Perhaps we should not be in too much of a hurry to refute realism, since a desire for comfort is unlikely to lead to clear thought. In considering the merits of realism, we should probably remember Mill’s remark that “it is a far from frequent accomplishment, even among thinkers, to know both sides; and the weakest part of what everybody says in defence of his opinion is what he intends as a reply to his antagonists.”⁵⁰ On the other hand, perhaps realism is a confused and pernicious view that should be rejected root and branch. Unfortunately, Mill’s remark has proven all too true with respect to the critics of realism: realism has often been caricatured by its opponents. Realists have often caricatured other traditions of thought as well. The aim of this volume is to get beyond these caricatures in order to understand what is really at issue between various traditions of thought about the ethics of war and peace.

One caricature to avoid is the widespread view of realism as a doctrine that recognizes no role for morality in international relations. Some realists have taken this extreme position, but this is not the best way of understanding the challenge that realism presents to other traditions of thought. It is better instead to focus on the question of whether it is *always* reasonable to demand that a state be prepared to sacrifice itself for the sake of morality. This is itself an extreme demand; in contrast, realism might argue that it represents a position of moderation in international affairs.⁵¹

NOTES

1. Of course, some realists do claim that there is a moral principle of national survival that entails that states have no right to pursue justice at the cost of security.
2. Thomas Hobbes, *Leviathan*, ch. 13.
3. Karl von Clausewitz, *On War*, ed. Michael Howard and Peter Paret (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1976), 77.
4. Clausewitz, *On War*, 76.
5. Clausewitz, *On War*, 87.
6. Clausewitz, *On War*, 581.
7. Hedley Bull, *The Anarchical Society* (New York: Columbia University Press, 1977), 185.
8. Robert E. Osgood and Robert W. Tucker, *Force, Order and Justice* (Baltimore: The Johns Hopkins University Press, 1967), 221.
9. Thucydides *The Peloponnesian War* bk. 3, "Civil War in Corcyra."
10. As Ted Koontz explains at the beginning of Chapter 9 below, there are many different ways of understanding nonviolence and pacifism. This section of my chapter focuses on the kind of pacifism that condemns war as a particular kind of violence.
11. Machiavelli, *The Prince*, ch. 15.
12. For an influential presentation of the view that we must give up the state, see Jonathan Schell, *The Fate of the Earth* (New York: Alfred A. Knopf, 1982); for a retraction of much of this view, see Jonathan Schell, *The Abolition* (New York: Alfred A. Knopf, 1984).
13. Kenneth Waltz, *Theory of International Politics* (New York: McGraw-Hill, 1979), 111–13.
14. See Osgood and Tucker, *Force, Order and Justice*, 336–41.
15. For an example of this sort of criticism, see Robert Holmes, *On War and Morality* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1989), 159–63.
16. Michael Walzer, *Just and Unjust Wars* (New York: Basic Books, 1977), 8.
17. Yehuda Melzer, *Concepts of Just War* (Leyden: A. W. Sijthoff), 106–8.
18. Michael Howard, *The Causes of Wars* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1983), 16.
19. See Marshall Cohen, "Moral Skepticism and International Relations," in Charles Beitz, Marshall Cohen, Thomas Scanlon, and A. John Simmons, eds., *International Ethics* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1985), 8–11.

20. This passage repeats the criticisms of the doctrine of collective security presented by Robert W. Tucker and David C. Hendrickson in *The Imperial Temptation: The New World Order and America's Purpose* (New York: Council on Foreign Relations Press, 1989), 43–52. For a somewhat different critique of collective security, see Richard K. Betts, “Systems for Peace or Causes for War: Collective Security, Arms Control, and the New Europe,” *International Security* 17 (1992), 5–43.

21. For some standard criticisms of the idea of the national interest, see Charles Beitz's discussion of Morgenthau in *Political Theory and International Relations* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1979), 24–25.

22. Kissinger, for example, offered this sort of rationale for pursuing detente with the Soviets.

23. David Grene, *Greek Political Theory: The Image of Man in Thucydides and Plato* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1965), 90.

24. See Osgood and Tucker, *Force, Order and Justice*, 282–84. Tucker does not use the terms “patriotic” and “liberal” reasons of state and distinguishes these positions in a slightly different way.

25. Lincoln's general respect for civil liberties during the American civil war illustrates how a liberal realist might try to cope with internal political resistance (if one doubts that Lincoln was a “realist,” consider his support for the way in which Grant and Sherman waged the war). Nevertheless, Lincoln felt compelled to suspend the writ of *habeas corpus* during the course of the war.

26. For an example of how a contemporary realist might approach the issue of intervention, see Hans Morgenthau, “To Intervene or Not to Intervene,” *Foreign Affairs* 45 (Apr. 1967). According to Morgenthau, the United States has intervened “not wisely but too well” (p. 434).

27. G.E.M. Anscombe, *Intention* (Ithaca, NY: Cornell University Press, 1957), 18. Anscombe adopts a view of intention as the answer to a certain kind of “why” question. As she notes, the distinction between intention and motive is sometimes unclear. Here I am following Anscombe in giving an example of what she calls “motive-in-general”: “To give a motive of the sort I have labelled ‘motive-in-general,’” she suggests, “is to say something like ‘See the action in this light.’” But “the question whether the light in which one so puts one's actions is a true light is a notoriously difficult one” (p. 21).

28. Since intentions may change, realists think states must also pay attention to “capabilities.” Foreign-policy debates between realists have recently been linked to the intentions/capabilities issue through the introduction of a “democracies are peaceful” thesis. Nixon, for example, called for massive aid to the former Soviet states on the basis of this thesis; Kissinger worried about restoring Russian capabilities.

29. See Holmes, *On Morality and War*, 114–46.

30. Machiavelli, *The Prince*, ch. 8.

31. Joel H. Rosenthal, *Righteous Realists: Political Realism, Responsible Power, and the American Culture in the Nuclear Age* (Baton Rouge: Louisiana State University Press, 1991), 42–46.

32. “The Profession and Vocation of Politics,” in Max Weber, *Political Writings*,

ed. Peter Lassman and Ronald Speirs (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1994), 309–69.

33. Reinhold Niebuhr, *The Irony of American History* (New York: Scribner, 1952), 23.

34. Machiavelli, *The Prince*, ch. 3.

35. Osgood and Tucker, *Force, Order and Justice*, 304.

36. Robert W. Tucker, *The Nuclear Debate: Deterrence and the Lapse of Faith* (New York: Holmes and Meier, 1985), 54.

37. For a sample of the recent debate, see *Journal of Medicine and Philosophy* 16 (1991), an issue devoted to the doctrine of double effect. For some criticisms of the doctrine, see Jonathan Bennett, “Intended as a Means,” in Sterling McMurrin, ed., *The Tanner Lectures on Human Values* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1981); and Nancy Davis, “The Doctrine of Double Effect: Problems of Interpretation,” *Pacific Philosophical Quarterly* 65 (1984), 107–23.

38. According to some realists, states accept this convention because of its utility. The utility of the convention in turn rests on reciprocity: when one belligerent begins to violate the combatant/noncombatant distinction, other belligerents have less reason to observe it.

39. Authors differ over whether this is a matter of self-defense or self-preservation. For the first view, see Robert Nozick, *Anarchy, State, and Utopia* (New York: Basic Books, 1968), 35; for the second, see Paul Woodruff, “Justification or Excuse: Saving Soldiers at the Expense of Civilians,” *Canadian Journal of Philosophy*, supp. vol. 8 (1982), 159–76.

40. Grene, *Greek Political Theory*, 84.

41. Robert E. Osgood, *Ideals and Self-Interest in America's Foreign Relations* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1953), 11.

42. See Gregory Kavka, *Hobbesian Moral and Political Theory* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1986), xi–xv, 29–83.

43. It is difficult to formulate this Hobbesian condition precisely. According to James Griffin, “Moral principles must be such that one's believing or accepting them will, conjoined with the threats and inducements that both morality and the facts of human psychology permit, determine action.” James Griffin, *Well-Being: Its Meaning, Measurement and Moral Importance* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1986), 350 n. 1.

44. Thucydides *The Peloponnesian War* 5.84–116.

45. Reinhold Niebuhr, *Moral Man and Immoral Society* (New York: Scribner, 1932), 83. In his later writings, Niebuhr modified his view that groups were incapable of self-sacrifice. See, for example, *Irony of American History*, 144–45.

46. Machiavelli and Hume have been interpreted as presenting versions of this argument. For this interpretation of Machiavelli, see Beitz, *Political Theory and International Relations*, 21–24; for this interpretation of Hume, see Cohen, “Moral Skepticism and International Relations,” 33–50.

47. For the argument that impersonal ethical systems like utilitarianism and Kantianism are too demanding, as well as the suggestion that we may have a prerogative to act against the impersonal point of view, see Bernard Williams, “Persons, Character, and Morality,” in Amelie Rorty, ed., *The Identities of Persons* (Berkeley and Los Angeles: University of California Press, 1976). For another ap-

proach, see Samuel Scheffler, *The Rejection of Consequentialism* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1982). Scheffler wants to modify consequentialist moral theory to make room for such a prerogative.

48. Walzer, *Just and Unjust Wars*, 8.

49. John Stuart Mill, *Utilitarianism*, 15th ed. (London: J. M. Dent and Sons, 1907), 81.

50. John Stuart Mill, *On Liberty*, in *Utilitarianism, On Liberty, Essay on Bentham*, ed. Mary Warnock (New York: New American Library, 1962), 172.

51. For comments on earlier drafts, thanks to Jackie Colby, David Goldfischer, David Hendrickson, Robert W. Tucker, and Terry Nardin.